COMMANDER GUIDE TO CAREERS

Gain the edge you need to succeed in your academic and career goals

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Academic and Professional Development Matter to Commanders

Commanders are often driven people, excited to put their ideas to work and seek out situations that test their intellect and limits. In school or at work, these types achieve as much as they let themselves. Demonstrating their capabilities gives them a magnetism that often invites others to follow their lead, and as elements in a group, these types can be inspiring and charismatic, helping everyone achieve more than they thought was possible. Few types can match them when it comes to determined persistence in pursuit of a goal – Commanders quickly assess what they want and how to get it, and they have the energy to make their desires a reality. It's not uncommon for these types to earn leadership positions.

These types excel at seeing how moving pieces can align most efficiently, even when those moving pieces consist of unique minds and seemingly irrational behaviors. Commanders can be hard on people – including themselves – but rational objectivity compels them to be fair. Although they rarely think twice about criticizing others whom they believe have fallen short, they tend to clearly communicate their expectations. Consciously building mutually rewarding social and intellectual cooperation in class or on the job gives Commanders the best chance of success in life.

To these types, the world often seems cut and dried, a place of losers and winners, and they strive to be in the latter camp. No other personality type is better suited to forging a positive future for themselves – and others. Firm and creative, Commanders aren't

content with complacency or ignoring areas of themselves that they can improve. They always want to better themselves and improve the world around them through lofty vision and vigorous action.

More Than Status

There's more to Commanders' academic and professional development than just the great strides that they seek to make in the world around them. It's true that their creative drive – and occasionally brash moves – are typically aimed at earning success and respect, but those aren't the only rewards that motivate them. As Extraverts, Commanders focus on externalizing their energy, ideas, and inspiration through action, partly because they're answering internal questions about themselves, for themselves.

Commanders test their mind and skills to find out what they're capable of, not just to reap the results that are available from society and others, but because it's part of the way that they solidify a lifelong foundation of self-respect and self-esteem. They aren't shy about reveling in whatever status they achieve, but it's also their raw ability to achieve that helps them value who they are. Whether Commanders are seeking to refute their insecurities or they simply have an exuberant desire to express themselves, academic and professional accomplishments are some of the most important ways that these bold personality types discover their own identity.

Little can truly satisfy a Commander as deeply as meeting their own metrics and goals, and that means that their educational and working experiences can also lead to healthy self-affirmation. That happens not only as a result of the external acclaim that their accomplishments may bring but also because Commanders learn to feel secure in their ability to shape their own destiny. As much as relationships with others can spell doom or success in social arenas like school or the workplace, Commanders are ultimately their own greatest allies. How they feel about themselves is key to their success, and every step in their development is an opportunity to celebrate their capability.

Want to boost your understanding of the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? Learn more here.

Academic Path

Being a student is a large part of life, and the question of whether to study in the classroom, in the workforce, or along the general path of life is up to the individual. Most people spend at least some of their formative years in a traditional school setting. No matter how long people remain in the academic world, the time that they spend there can be valuable, if they so choose. These years can not only determine a career path but can also affect self-esteem and other aspects of personal psychology well into the future – in both positive and negative ways.

Commanders see education as a means to an end. People with this personality type, being strategic long-term planners, set goals and then work furiously toward them, using all resources at their disposal, including the tool of education. They regard knowledge and skill as cornerstones upon which they can build a better future for themselves, and they work to prepare accordingly for that future.

To maximize the benefits of their education, it's useful for these types to fully explore their interests and preferences. It's also important to remember that all personality types have weaknesses to deal with, and it's no different for Commanders, who are likely to dismiss their shortcomings as trivialities. It's helpful to address these challenges, and Commanders' appetite for knowledge and reason gives them a strong foundation for dealing with both their positive and negative tendencies, especially when it comes to the world of learning.

How Commanders Learn

Commanders love problems that need solving. When they look at systems or designs, they're able to see them in their entirety – including what they could be and what's currently missing that keeps them from their full potential. If these flaws and gaps bother Commanders enough, they feel compelled to fix them. However, it's a mistake to characterize Commanders' pursuit of knowledge as a matter of application alone. These types strive to feel challenged by the path they're on. Innovation, improvement, and logical progress matter a great deal and help fuel their motivation to learn. If their learning paths need fixing, they step in and address them by way of formal education, on-the-job training, or independent skill building.

Balanced Learning Habits

Knowing When to Rest

Academic success for these types may look like being the best at a chosen skill within their peer group – whether that skill is perfecting spreadsheets, mastering the clarinet, or being the student with the most trophies in basketball. To achieve their personal idea of success, they develop the ability to push past both physical and mental barriers to meet their goals. When taking a balanced approach to their studies, however, Commanders, more importantly, also know when to rest.

When it comes to choosing those periods of rest, Commanders may turn to their rationalist attitude and respect for systems and research, opening themselves to effective techniques proven by a respected authority. This is a type who might, for example, read about effective study methods in a psychology textbook and make the connection between the text and their own day-to-day behaviors. Research shows that rest makes things work better, and specific study methods can increase retention better than others. Commanders are likely to test these theories, then commit to them if they appear valid.

Expressing Openness

It would be inaccurate to call Commanders close-minded. Understanding reality depends on their being willing to consider new ideas, a need that's core to Commanders' values. This open-mindedness is a result of

their Extraverted and Intuitive traits working together, raking through concepts and ideas from either their immediate network or more global inspiration. Commanders who take this balanced approach to exchanging ideas allow others to express their thoughts, and, in turn, these types provide insightful, constructive criticism or an eagerness to implement these new concepts.

Such open-mindedness can be crucial to Commanders' progress in academics. They understand that, while their ideas are brilliant, they can be even more so when they collaborate with their fellow students or instructors. This can look like discussing with a professor why they disagree with a lesson or method of teaching, but then being open to the professor explaining the benefits of their approach, which Commanders can then test out for themselves. In the end, Commanders are concerned with what can optimize a situation.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Burning Out

Commanders may mistake working themselves to the bone as "discipline." Rather than allowing themselves to relish their current academic success, they instead may push full speed ahead toward long-term goals, putting off contentment and fulfillment until a vague point in the future when all their ducks are entirely lined up in a row. There's a difference between doing well in the "Marshmallow Test" – or delaying one's gratification to reap a greater reward later – and an outright inability to feel pleasure.

These students may feel guilty for giving themselves time to rest. They may even fear being out-worked by others, forgetting that other students' successes don't mean their own failure. This fear can lead them to an intense rut, and, in the worst-case scenarios, burning out completely. In the end, they may become what they fear most – counterproductive.

Closed to Other Ideas

Commanders can be very unsupportive of any ideas that distract from their primary goals, and even more so of ideas based on emotional

considerations. When taken too far, they won't hesitate to make this clear to those around them, regardless of how it makes people feel. It's not unusual to see Commanders toss out seemingly incompetent classmates from group work, or completely disregard teachers as undeserving of their attention. Although this may work in some areas of life, it may not be the best route when it comes to learning, which is largely about accepting new perspectives. Commanders who take an unbalanced approach may burn every bridge in sight and stunt their academic growth.

In an academic setting, this could look like Commanders marshaling a group project – but before the group can even get together, they have the direction and objective set without anyone else's input. While this by itself isn't inherently bad, it can easily become so when they're also unwilling to accept any other suggestions throughout the rest of the project.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Creating a Leisure Budget

Commander students may think it's a good idea to work themselves ragged. However, one of the best things they can do for themselves is to reframe the idea of "rest" as something beneficial rather than a waste of time. Without rest, these types can find themselves burning out and reducing their productivity. By incorporating rest into their schedule, or creating blocks for leisure time, Commanders can find themselves in peak condition to take on their studies.

There have been several studies conducted that suggest working long, unbroken hours may be the *worst* thing one can do for productivity. In the medical journal *Frontiers in Human Neuroscience*, the research of Dr. Simone M. Ritter and Dr. Ap Dijksterhuis suggests that a "mental fixation" on a task can impede the generation of new and appropriate ideas, a concept that would be appalling to progress-concerned Commanders. In the following exercise, Commanders can create a "leisure budget" for themselves. Just as they manage how much time they put into external projects, they can also manage how much time they reserve for mental and physical recuperation. Here's how:

- This "leisure budget" should begin small at first – 15 minutes a day, every day, for a month.
- Make this 15 minutes a completable "task" to ease any guilt for not being "productive."
- Each month, increase the time by 15-minute increments until a "leisure budget" of at least 45 minutes is achieved.

OR

- Set a timer for 50 minutes.
- Work for 50 minutes.
- Once the timer goes off, close the laptop/notebook/PowerPoint.
- Set another timer for 17 minutes.
- Walk away from the work station.
- During the next 17 minutes, Commanders can take a walk, exercise, or grab a snack.
- Once the 17 minutes is up, return to the work station and set another timer for 50 minutes, and repeat the process.

One of the most important lessons these students can learn is knowing when to allow time for rest. Commanders work like well-oiled machines, but sometimes these machines begin to overheat from overuse. Although they can see the most optimal path from point A to point B, they often sacrifice their well-being for their goals. By implementing rest and relaxation into their routine, even in small doses, Commanders can increase their productivity, reduce stress, extend academic longevity, and become more efficient overall.

Catching Flies with Honey

Commanders should remember they don't have to burn bridges or invalidate others to get their points across. This isn't to say these students should try to change themselves to be soft-hearted. Instead, they can use their powerful abilities to lead and cultivate relationships with others rather than bulldoze them.

A more equitable, respectful approach still allows Commanders to be bold and opinionated, expressing their views honestly. The key to not alienating others is the ability to accept dualism – to say, "That's an interesting point of view," instead of, "Your perspective doesn't match with my own, and here's why you're likely wrong..." With some subtle changes in presentation, they'll find they earn much more status and respect by being polite. They can do this by using this interpersonal effectiveness exercise:

- Approach others in a gentle and non-threatening manner, avoiding attacks and judgmental statements.
    - "Non-threatening" can mean allowing a half-smile or avoiding constant eye contact to avoid intimidating fellow students.
- Choose to be interested in listening to others without interrupting.
    - If time is of the utmost importance, Commanders can share a set amount of time to listen to others. For example, "Hey! While I'd love to talk to more, I have a big essay due. I'm happy to take a few minutes, however."
- Validate and acknowledge others' wishes, feelings, or opinions.
    - Validating doesn't mean concession. Instead, it means giving merit to another opinion – an "I see what you mean" type of response.

In the end, it's important for Commanders to remember that using the above exercise is meant to temper their bluntness, not replace it. Their ability to prioritize and speak frankly is why they tend to be very effective people – but some situations call for validating others and expressing openness.

Commanders in High School

In high school, teachers are likely to see Commander students as dominant figures in their peer groups. Enthusiastic Commanders relish class discussions as opportunities to not only swim in a sea of ideas but also discern which ideas are important. This is perhaps the best thing about learning for these innovative people.

Commanders embrace high standards, even when young. They dedicate vast amounts of time and effort to solving complex problems

or unraveling mysteries. But even when they falter, with their raw drive, they can pull through. Their curiosity is an advantage, especially when it comes to the energy they apply to studying.

Balanced High School Learning

Allowing Room for "Not Yet"

Commanders in high school are like all other personality types – they're young. Being young doesn't diminish their motivation to succeed or lead, but it can make it confusing to know which direction to point their skills. Those who take a balanced approach to high school understand that while they might be young and ambitious, it's also all right to explore and fail in different subjects. They strive for excellence, yes, but these students try not to beat themselves up for not mastering Numerical Linear Algebra at age sixteen.

For Commanders who take a balanced approach, receiving a less-than-stellar grade on an exam or receiving a less-than-elite score or ranking in a chosen extracurricular means allowing themselves to feel disappointed, but not defeated. They won't say to themselves, "I'll *never* be where I'd like to with X," but instead, "I'm not where I would like to be with X **yet**." That "yet" makes all the difference, as they'll give themselves time to rest before embarking on another learning journey knowing that failing is key to progress.

Fair to Themselves and Others

Along with self-compassion in the face of failure, Commander students who take a balanced approach learn to develop tolerance for their schoolmates and teachers. This isn't to say they enjoy incompetence, but they do learn to be fair by checking in with themselves and others. In this case, being fair means creating room for opposing opinions or perspectives, and gently, but sternly, redirecting their peers' off-track opinions with ample factual evidence. They also allow themselves to be wrong, as it's only fair to their own sense of progression. Instead of perceiving being wrong as a setback, they take it as an opportunity to improve their knowledge base.

In high school, Commanders who take a balanced approach to fairness, while also staying true to themselves, consider opinions or viewpoints they're otherwise not naturally drawn toward. They allow people to prove their points and take time to understand the relevance of seemingly mundane subjects. It isn't about being right, or being open to anything and everything, but giving themselves the chance to learn something new by allowing room for fallibility.

Unbalanced High School Learning

Failing an Idealized Self

Commanders tend to have an idealized vision of the world, but this vision begins with themselves – types who are well-educated, well-spoken, open-minded, efficient, and never willing to "settle for less." This, however, is an unrealistic expectation to have for anyone, let alone themselves. Unfortunately, these innovative types can be beyond hard on themselves for mistakes that everyone makes. Their strict personal philosophies rely on determination and discipline, and, when unbalanced, may make it difficult for Commander students to consider settling for "failure" if they see it as a flaw and not a normal, human experience.

These types can endow a failing grade with exaggerated meaning, far beyond any practical consequence. For example, failing a math class can risk Commanders' self-identifying as trail-blazing engineers, or not meeting their own expectations in an art class can risk their self-identifying as creative, problem-solving people.

With such a high premium placed on intelligent competence, failure seems like a direct threat to Commanders' identity, and may lead them to believe that a 'C' in a class directly correlates to unfulfilled ambitions. They may think terrible, but false, thoughts about themselves – deeming themselves lazy, incapable of working smart enough, or, with a fatalistic sigh, "*I'm not good enough and never will be*." If their core identity constructs come under fire, their singular focus leaves them with few other identity markers to turn to – and can leave them feeling destroyed.

No Room for Alternatives

While approaching differing views with patience and open-mindedness works for some Commanders, others may struggle. Some of these students dismiss giving themselves time or attention to branch out. They may even justify their opposition based on unyielding principles alone. They may be visionaries when it comes to the broader strokes of their plans, but not even Commanders can anticipate exactly what the future holds. By holding too stubbornly to their beliefs, they may disregard conflicting but essential data, or entire fields of research and discussion, rather than revising their worldviews to accommodate them.

Their reluctance to accommodate alternative views is a result of Commanders' combined Intuitive and Judging traits. In their minds, they see the ideal, "perfect" ways to do things (the correct answer to questions, the appropriate experiments to conduct for unknown variables, or the most effective ways to present group projects), and they try to mold the imperfect models before them into those that match the images in their heads. However, the pursuit of these singular, perfect solutions can lead them to be dangerously closed-minded to the possibility that they could be wrong.

Rebalancing High School Learning

Creating Diversified Identities

Commanders are relentless in their pursuit when determined. No matter what it takes – blood, sweat, or tears – they'll achieve their goal once they decide what it is. The problem with this, however, is they risk a lack of awareness for anything beyond that goal.

These students may make the mistake of pigeonholing themselves into one subject with a dedication that's amazing but also limiting. They may even learn everything that's relevant to the goal in mind – being a nationally ranked teen mathlete, for example – instead of learning what they want to learn.

Although joining the astronomy club, reading a book on Antarctica, or listening to informational videos online are all worthy pursuits, these

types may feel they just can't afford the "bandwidth" to do so at the expense of their bigger goals.

To balance this, Commanders can make time to research their more tangential interests. They can do this by:

- Thinking back on things they once thought interesting but didn't try because they weren't relevant to their goals. Consider, for example, Commanders who thoroughly enjoyed a theater class, but couldn't take time away from their pursuit of biology.
    - In our example, they can join a "theater geek" friend in producing a single play (they always want a willing extra). This provides the opportunity to explore this interest without the pressure of taking on a full elective.
- Then, they can take the time to decipher if the new interest is enriching their lives rather than burdening them.
    - If yes, stay.
    - If no, leave.

By creating diversified identities, Commanders aren't likely to lose their *whole* sense of identity should one fall through. Even if they suddenly stop being A+ students, they can still be president of the debate team, a casual inventor, an effective mentor, and so on.

Having Fair Consideration

When it comes to having fair consideration, Commanders can practice stepping into another's argument or perspective to take a more balanced view of both the issue at hand and their own perspective. It's playing chess against themselves – if they know all the moves on both sides, then they can force themselves to consider a much more objective, multifaceted analysis of the board.

This can work especially well when it comes to drafting papers that require them to respond to issues. Rather than responding based only on their personal views, Commander students can open themselves to other schools of thought. Learning more about contrary ideas allows them to see the weak points in their own arguments as well as the strengths,

allowing them to present well-rounded papers or arguments that address both sides. The same thing can be said for group projects. When it comes to collaboration, the best ideas come from respectful conflict.

Here's how Commanders can pursue discussions in good faith:

- When they consider a topic or another person's views that directly opposes their own beliefs, they can ask:
  - "How?" and "Why?" of the person, or do research on the conflicting idea.
  - Listen or research without making any initial judgments while giving the benefit of the doubt.
  - Process the information.
  - See how it compares against their own knowledge set.

By hearing these new ideas out objectively, Commander high school students, with their strongly developed ability to make decisions, can find comfort in the fact that they're making the most informed choices.

Choosing Work or College

Though Commanders are by many measures an uncommon personality type, they face a common dilemma when leaving high school: should they immediately go into the world of work, or should they continue their studies?

Choosing College

For some, the choice is moot – academic certification is a requirement for many occupations they might be drawn to, including business, engineering, healthcare, and law. Without attending college, the doors they long to open can remain locked. These Commanders have a non-negotiable stopover on their life journey.

The experience doesn't need to be a chore, and many Commanders find their crusade to innovate humanity to be an integral part of their chosen curriculum. In college, they may likely find opportunities to make necessary connections and climb whatever ladders to reach their end goals.

Choosing Work

There are Commanders who choose work over attending a university, who cannot bear the costs of college – whether personal, financial, practical, or principled – or whose zeal for their goals is so potent that they just can't be deferred any longer. No longer guided by educational pursuits or their parents, these Commanders need time to define themselves and their goals. It's also reasonable to work in entry-level positions – like waiting tables or doing physical work – while continuing a path of self-discovery outside the regimen of school and parental oversight. Actively exploring interests and perhaps saving money for future schooling is a balanced reason to delay college in favor of the working world.

Others know full well what they want and find rewarding careers or choose to work for themselves. They might also take paths somewhere in between, like doing odd jobs to build a portfolio for a future entrepreneurial venture, or using a passion for writing to contribute freelance articles while dealing with the reality of paying the bills.

It's important for Commanders to realize that many roads can be rewarding. If they truly wish to create a brilliant and efficient world, they'll find a way to do so, even if their path toward doing so is different than they (or others) originally anticipated.

Balanced Decision-Making

Embracing Honesty

The important thing is for these types to consider their options with unwavering honesty. The difficulty of this task shouldn't be underestimated. When surveying the world through a healthy lens, Commanders know perhaps better than anyone how good people are at deceiving themselves. Those who recognize this very human tendency within themselves ask questions, consult with friends and mentors, and do other internal and external reality checks that gather a range of opinions and information to help orient and clarify their goals.

Any option can be just the challenge Commanders need to move their visions forward, or a means of escape from the weight of responsibility.

It can be all too easy to convince themselves that one is the other. When honest and patient with themselves, Commanders distinguish between an obstacle and an excuse, and they progress.

Following Through

Students leaning toward college understand that it's a long commitment – which is fine, since Commanders strive to follow through on their convictions. They recognize that time spent toward self-improvement isn't selfish (it's the nature of ambition to prioritize one's own goals), especially if it provides them with the credentials necessary to enter their chosen professions – or to use their education to create efficient intellectual frameworks for the personal or global problems they long to solve.

When taking a balanced approach, Commander students embrace the idea that attending college isn't an abdication of responsibilities but an acceptance of them – if time there is used effectively. On the opposite side, Commanders who don't seek out college can still find ways to advance their goals. Even entry-level service industry positions can be meaningful if they find satisfaction in their community of coworkers and customers. It can also support them financially while they dedicate time to their "true" careers, especially if the skills developed during their employment makes them more viable candidates for positions in fields of their choosing.

With this acceptance, they dedicate themselves to challenging but necessary work – whether it be in a classroom or earning a living – while maintaining their responsibility to themselves with much-needed relaxation.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Eternally Waiting

These types can pick up the unhealthy habit of spending their whole lives waiting for the perfect opportunity to arrive. The post-high school period is a time of exceptional personal consequence, and younger Commanders may allow the importance of making decisions to become exaggerated in their minds, sinking them into inaction. There's something better right around the corner, they may think, while letting

opportunity after opportunity pass them by. Their Intuition, though a powerful tool, can be used against them here as they imagine perfectly-formed solutions falling into their laps. They're highly vigilant when it comes to opportunities, with none of them being "good enough," or their costs being too great.

This combination of imagination and rumination manifests itself in Commanders' inaction. These types may wait for the perfect opportunity from the great unknown to dictate their next course of action – a specific perfect situation to become an author, or to go to a certain university. They may spend more time trying to *decide* if something is right, instead of acting to *make* it meet their version of "perfect." Commanders who spend years agonizing over a course of study or type of employment may eventually find that little was gained from their excessive deliberation, and much perhaps was lost.

Haunted Rumination

Choices that are later seen as "wrong" have a way of haunting these types as well. Living with choices is as necessary for Commanders as making them in the first place, but when they overanalyze both their past and future decisions, this unbalanced view gives them little chance to develop the self-confidence or self-forgiveness to see them through.

What they may not realize is that endless rumination and self-consumption is itself a decision. It's a choice not to act or progress, and a decision that can cost far more time than either attending school or making a more intentional push into the professional world. They may be so afraid of making the wrong choice that they choose none at all, instead falling into a path that doesn't align with their personal values.

Ten years hence, their regret is likely to be that they're no closer to their goals because they never acted to bring those goals forward.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

Adjusting Course

Commanders' sense of delay comes from their need to commit once they've chosen a course of action. When nothing can be undone, the

only choice is the well-considered decision, and what counts as "well-considered" can be stretched to infinity. The question is whether this deliberation arises out of sensible caution, or a fear of the unknown and the lack of self-confidence needed to step into that abyss.

It's important for Commanders to understand that few decisions are permanent. Changing their mind based on new information isn't only their prerogative, but a sign of maturity. Snap decision-making always feels unnatural to Commanders, but those who err a bit more on the side of rashness – at least compared to their usual resolution – may find that even when they've made a wrong choice, the consequences may not be nearly as irreversible as they feared.

Here are some tips for Commanders adjusting their course, as it's never too late to act:

- Request a tour of a local university (likely through their Welcome Center, should they have one).
- Visit an organization's Facebook page or a campus website to look at their events calendar and gather information.
- Attend an information walkthrough of a university or local college.
- Request an informational interview with an interesting company or non-governmental organization through their human resources department.

In the end, there's no commitment needed to do these things. Commanders are on fact-finding missions and should feel no pressure to sign up for anything. Hopefully, though, they'll feel the rush of inspiration fill them again, and find they're off on another life chapter.

Commitment with Contingencies

No one can truly convince Commanders to do anything. Any decision they make must be made on their terms. But they can be encouraged to keep the bigger picture in mind. This is a personality type with powerful Intuition, even when they're young, and they tend to want to be the best version of themselves – and the best in general.

However, this can lead to a nasty case of over-rumination. Luckily, Commander students who find themselves haunted by past musings can happily remember that nothing is stopping them from making their own blend of education and work experience now. This is a type who rarely suffers from a lack of bold action, and there's no one single way to concoct an amazing learning experience. They can develop a game plan for what they want, and then execute it as they see fit.

To help them with their decision-making, they can try this exercise that evaluates two or more paths they'd like to explore and possibly pursue:

- Decide on two distinct tracks, whether they're in higher education or the workforce. For example, they can put down their desire to pursue an architecture degree from a university, plus their interest in going to work at a construction design business to get hands-on experience.
- Map out coursework and requirements for both the tracks.
- After mapping out the requirements, search for points of interaction between them, such as:
  - Shared prerequisites
  - Overlap of subject material or interest
  - Potential networking opportunities that can get them to their end goals

By doing this exercise, Commanders can find overlapping potential in each of their tracks, some of which may lead to the same point. This way, they'll find it's not possible for at least taking *those* courses of action to be "wrong." They're all valuable in their own right.

Commanders in College

Young Commanders who chafed against the mundane curricula of high school may see college as a place to spread their wings. Although the liberty of higher learning can spell out unlimited freedom to sociable, whip-smart Commanders, college also has its challenges. It isn't that these types won't be able to handle the expectations and workload that comes with university life, it's that there may be too

many choices – too many extracurriculars, too many subjects to be explored, and, as always, those "annoying and useless" prerequisites.

College is the prime place for Commander students to prove their mettle. For perhaps the first time in their lives, they're in an arena that, while still limited, pushes them to discover what their passions are. Where they once saw no worthy academic opponents, they'll now see many. But Commanders aren't easily cowed. They both love and thrive on competition.

Commanders can finally explore their Extraversion without the rules they were subject to when they were younger. They may write a revolutionary thesis, or network to find their perfect future career, and partake in keggers every night. However, this enjoyment won't be without purpose. Commanders are making the social connections they know can help them in the future.

Balanced Approach to College

Utilizing Competitors

College is a time for Commanders to find kindred spirits in the classroom and study groups. When taking a balanced approach, these students welcome those with a similar work ethic or same field of study, and befriend these classmates or mentors knowing that while they may be competing, there's also a chance they'll learn from each other.

Commanders tend to utilize their competitors by seeing who can write a more eloquent paper, or create the most functional program, or carve the best sculpture. They also work with competitors to see the weak points in their own performance, and gain inspiration from others' truly amazing work. When Commanders take a balanced approach to college, they learn how to utilize the talents of others and find how satisfying collaboration and competition can be.

Sprinkling in Fun

Commanders look for systems and interesting implementations of ideas, and they use this ability to choose the right tools for their college careers. Whatever their paths may be, when they take a balanced

approach they're able to mix activities that are required, though taxing, with activities that are for sheer fun.

For example, when these Commanders choose Mechanical Engineering as their focus of study, they'll do all the required geometry, fluid mechanics, and simulation modeling work, but they'll also take a night off to upgrade an old car with completely superfluous parts to make it go much, *much* faster. While they're dedicated to their paths, they also understand the importance of sprinkling their workloads with innovative joy to keep them passionate.

Unbalanced College Life

The Know-It-All

Commanders, unfortunately, can frequently become founts of opinion rather than knowledge. It takes very little actual learning for them to seem wise, as their fertile minds make the best use of information and facts. Those who take an unbalanced approach can have an inflated sense of their knowledge, making them closed off to inspiration from their competitors. This mistake can poison potential achievements and deny Commanders of what could be brilliant collaborations.

Those who decide they already know "enough" can sink themselves into a veritable pit of creativity. Their strong desire to express themselves makes it hard for these types to be humble, but it's truly a shame if they allow their lack of humility to stifle their ability to learn.

If they do decide to work with others, they may still detrimentally let their strong views influence their interests and what they're willing to learn, focusing only on areas they already have interest and experience in rather than broadening their scope. While any learning is good, failing to expand significantly beyond areas they already know won't give these types a chance to grow and fully express their awesome potential.

Overload

In their desire to set solid foundations while in college, it's natural for Commander students to overload themselves. Whether it's the

pressures of school requirements or the expectations they pile on themselves, sooner or later, Commanders typically deal with the question of overload. Those who haven't learned the art of self-care can become overwhelmed and stressed.

In high school, Commanders' ability to stress themselves out may not have been as serious, thanks to smaller workloads and fewer expectations. In college, however, Commanders have free rein to express their perfectionism within their chosen courses and activities. They also add stress to their lives by pushing for too much detail and making excessive demands of themselves. These demands may look like they're not cutting themselves enough slack when they make mistakes, pushing themselves too hard to achieve and maintain high grades, and simultaneously pushing themselves to meet high social expectation.

As the pressure becomes heavier and heavier, Commanders tend to continue to press themselves further even as they begin to falter under pressure. Despite their determined brows, the stress can erode not only their effectiveness but also their morale. Instead of a rewarding experience, the college years can soon represent drudgery, regret, and burnout.

Rebalancing College Life

Recognizing the Strength in Others

Commanders can tap into their logic to rebalance any ill-will they have toward competitors and get their minds back to being the wonderful sponges that they are. To attain a sense of balance, these types can talk to those who are far more advanced in areas in which they have interest. Nothing provides a sense of humility like seeing the vastness of potential accomplishments stretching ahead. This is where Commanders' ego and drive can become assets. They might not know everything yet, but they darn well can if they utilize their competitors' minds.

This process of opening themselves up to new types of knowledge or experiences can push these students to a whole new level of their education. What's key here is accepting that they have a lot yet to learn,

and then setting out to vigorously seek knowledge. Where and how to best continue their education becomes apparent when Commanders humble themselves enough to admit that while they may need help that their competitors can provide, it certainly wouldn't hurt them to *want* new perspectives. The following exercise has Commanders work alongside perceived competitors to see how their processes compare. Here's how they can open themselves up to competitors:

- Commanders can create a study group or work session with other students in their courses.
- Invite their perceived competitors to group sessions. Try to invite two or more students who have talents or specialties that Commanders would like to explore further.
- During these sessions, Commanders can pay attention to their competitors' processes.
    - They can take note of differences in the processes.
    - They can take note of similarities in the processes.
    - They can take note of any innovations in the processes.
- Commanders should also be open to sharing their own process.
- Commanders can objectively compare the work of their competitors to their own, and either:
    - Subtract something from their process to create an objectively better piece of work.
    - Add something to their process to create an objectively better piece of work.

In the end, Commanders may either gain inspiration from their competitors or, better yet, inspiration from the work they create under the kiln of competition. Whichever paths they choose, these students are likely to have a better piece of work.

Reshaping Unreasonable Expectations

While Commanders in high school have issues with taking breaks, those in college may be unwilling to deal with the root of their stress – meeting

unreasonable expectations. It's important for individual Commanders to define what an unreasonable expectation looks like, and while the answers can be varied, they all come back to a single baseline question that they can ask themselves: "Am I burning out too often?" If they feel that their expectations are leading them to dread their upcoming days, and make them counterproductive by overloading them with stress, then it may be time for these students to make a change.

The first step is to acknowledge they've created an unreasonable situation for themselves by asking, "Would I ask someone else to do all these things? Would I wish this schedule on my best friend?" While they may project their expectations onto others at first, their more rational side is likely to give an objective answer. A realistic assessment is an important step in goal-setting.

Commanders suffer in silence because they believe they should be able to handle everything expected of them. They view meeting expectations, no matter how unreasonable, as a duty; they grit their teeth and bear the pain. However, to be better-rounded people, it's necessary to understand that it's okay not to be okay sometimes. Pain, discomfort, and emotional stress are early warning systems that alert people to change course or suffer further damage to their well-being. Commanders help themselves when they learn to treat their different feelings with respect and heed the information they provide.

Becoming literate in the language of one's own feelings can be as simple as raising awareness. One method involves setting a random alarm on one's phone or watch to go off at unexpected intervals. When the alarm sounds, make a note somewhere with the answers to two questions:

- "What is my current feeling?"
- "What is the feeling telling me?"
- For example, perhaps "discouragement" is the current feeling, and it's foreshadowing an impossible afternoon filled with too many arduous tasks.

Many disciplined Commanders teach themselves to ignore their feelings. Bringing emotions back into the conversation can help them deal better with unreasonable expectations and consider their own

well-being more often. Commanders can prevent burnout by recognizing their basic needs, learning how they may not be fulfilling them, and then addressing them. Once they've taken care of themselves, they can once again attend to their brilliant ideas.

Lifelong Learning

Lifelong learning goes beyond the rigors of school, though a return to academia is certainly an option. Older individuals who have embraced themselves fully are better able to give the benefit of the doubt to areas of study or schools of thought that might have struck them as irrelevant or not worth their time in their younger years.

Of all the personality types, Commanders are among those who feel most comfortable with the prospect of lifelong learning, the notion that education isn't a thing that one may possess, nor something one must get from some institution, but is instead a never-ending journey that can always satisfy. They know that they can never truly fulfill their hunger for knowledge, just as they can never sate their yen for innovation and efficiency, and find joy in that knowledge.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Finding Joy in Learning

Understanding there's beauty in a clumsy first effort – just as there's beauty in a child's excitement when they first learn that red and yellow make orange – Commanders who take a balanced approach to lifelong learning pursue many things that some people only attempt in childhood. They grant themselves permission to find joy in their learning, whether it be playing a new instrument, speaking another language, taking up a dance style, joining in an unfamiliar sport or game, discovering metal making, or learning about nature. Their pursuits can include anyone and anything that brings them joy and fulfillment.

Many contented Commanders continue to learn throughout their lives, not to prove something to someone – least of all themselves – but for the joy of trying something and getting better at it. They tend to do something because it's fun, not because it serves some greater purpose

(though that's by no means off-limits). Engaging the world around them with no agenda but curiosity resonates with Commanders' drive to always be inspired.

Enjoying Learning over Improvement

Self-improvement is important, but enjoying oneself in the process is even more so. Commanders who decide to take a more balanced approach to lifelong learning try to appreciate the lives they've developed for themselves, as well as praise themselves for the skills they've learned. By taking time to practice appreciation, Commanders gain a certain self-awareness that lessens the fear that they're not learning anything at all, or that they're "stuck in the mud." What comes with this is also the ability to separate learning a new skill from needing to perform it *well* the first time around.

In fact, these types may separate learning new skills from their self-image completely. They feel accomplished when they succeed at something, but don't base their self-worth on what they've learned (or failed to learn). This is a personality type who accepts themselves as they are, but who also strives to learn when they can.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

Stubborn Worldviews

From an early age, Commanders tend to formulate a cohesive set of opinions about the world. Those who refuse to adjust these ideas when appropriate may find themselves lacking. They focus on subjects they already have an affinity for, rather than diversifying their learning. When they do deepen their understanding with this mindset, they often only pursue knowledge that supports their fundamental views. This limits their growth, and even solidifies their ignorance, as they focus on one thing without truly having an open mind to others.

Unfortunately, while some Commanders recognize and compensate for their certitude, knowing that different perspectives bring forward different and equal truths about the world, others just allow their beliefs to congeal into an impenetrable ideological mass. This can conflict with their perception of themselves as fundamentally correct in their

worldview. While the planet changes around them, these Commanders may be reluctant to learn about new technologies, philosophies, or methods, always considering their own to be better than the rest.

Making the Magnificent the Mundane

Aside from the diminishing returns of a too-narrow focus, those who refuse to work at diversifying their learning and self-exploration risk growing weary of the very obsessions that once inflamed them. An over-serious approach to knowledge robs them of the joy of learning and discovery – unable to divert their attention from their mission, whether fixing the world's inefficiency or exercising their inventiveness, the pure pleasure of a day off to learn a light-hearted skill can become perverse and selfish in their eyes.

This unrelenting, adamant nature can hold these types back as powerfully as it once propelled them forth. Once just one strong argument away from changing the world, those suffering a severe case of burnout may be equally certain that no such argument exists – or if one does, it's everyone else who's too stubborn and apathetic to make it. Where an early cynicism has its disadvantages, the late-blooming cynicism that can grip the heart of older Commanders may be particularly devastating. With nothing to replace their former passion, they can quickly become despondent, so certain are they that every alternative course was ruled out in their youth.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Broadening Scope

It's important to note that, while their formative years might be well-spent becoming authorities in their chosen careers, as Commanders mature they might find at least some of their time better spent attaining a greater breadth of knowledge. Seemingly unrelated topics could yield fresh insight into their principal areas of concern.

Being "set in your ways" isn't inherently bad. However, there's always room for improving on existing routines. Commanders can begin this by picking a contrary opinion. Take, for example, a supportive opinion on the merits of learning about their town's local political climate, when

Commanders prefer to stick to what they already know. Here are some steps they can follow:

- Rather than immediately dismissing an argument, Commanders can choose to take time to understand the other side. Even a small variation can loosen up the tight grip existing routine has on life and begin to open new vistas of learning. The following things they can consider are:
    - How their own stance may appear to others.
    - Some benefits of what the other side may be proposing.
    - Perhaps "trying on" the contrary opinion themselves for a few minutes by switching roles with their discussion partner.
- Based on these small excursions, Commanders can then adjust their routines based on what they liked or disliked.

There's always new experiences to have and new things to learn. They don't have to be earth-shaking or life-changing. Learning can benefit life without being too disruptive.

Once they rediscover the joy in learning something new, Commanders might choose to stretch their experience even more. They may find the benefit of continued learning far outweighs any risk.

Connecting Mundane to Magnificent

Commanders' greatest peril is that learning becomes a joyless process, and this is because they tend to get carried away with the scope of learning new things. If they're practicing the violin, for example, they may think, "How can I possibly compare to a master violinist? There's just so far to go." Learning stops being fun and starts being something that seems burdensome.

To rebalance this, however, these types can connect the mundane to make it magnificent once more. Learning, rather than being something they ruminate upon, can become an opportunity to reconnect with their friends, family, and community. It's a reconnection with what makes humanity beautiful, and that upwelling of pure, positive emotion can breathe new life into the darkest struggles. A good way Commanders

can do this is through simple mindfulness exercises. Here are a few steps that they can follow:

- Find an object to focus on. It can be:
  - A plant
  - A cup
  - A body of water
- Take a few minutes to focus on the simplest aspects of the object:
  - What colors are there to it?
  - What is the texture of its surface?
  - Does it have a scent?
  - What are its physical features?

Doing this simple exercise only takes about five minutes, and does a very good job of pulling Commanders out of a bad headspace and into the reality around them. They can focus on what's in front of them in that moment.

Conclusion

Students of Life

Education means a lot of things to a lot of people. For Commanders, it's a way to advance in life to achieve not only goals for themselves, but goals for humanity at large. Commanders' challenge isn't so much in the hard work of learning. It's more about managing expectations and finding a reasonable pace so that learning doesn't become a soulless drudgery or an overwhelming burden, but a rewarding experience that adds to life. For these types, balance involves blending their determination and heart with pragmatism and realistic expectations – a balance that's quite achievable.

Taking time aside for their own needs, setting plausible expectations for themselves, finding meaning and merit in the mundane, understanding

that an 'A+' doesn't equate to self-worth, and allowing themselves room to fail and to be wrong allows Commanders to celebrate their failures right alongside their accomplishments as acts of learning.

In the end, it's important to note that people are never truly balanced or unbalanced. All of us, as a collective, are going back and forth, evolving and devolving. Balance is more akin to seasons as they come and go, cycling gracefully (or not so much) forever. The trees are taller, people are wiser, all of us advancing in our way. Progress comes in the form of learning how to deal with those seasons and is an extension of Commanders' journeys toward personal growth.

Professional Development

This chapter explores how Commanders can be successful in professional arenas and offers guidance on potential career paths. Commanders typically are most comfortable in fields that allow them to create or contribute to rational efficiency. Once they discover a job that fulfills this need, their sense of personal pride propels them to do the best work possible. If a position doesn't fit at first, this dynamic type works to change the environment little by little – or a lot. Eventually, the job may come closer to matching their personal standards. Commanders are unlikely to be passive about their approach to work.

We'll start by looking broadly at the ways Commanders approach working life, including their strengths and the challenges they face. Next, we'll see how people with this personality type can apply their dedicated efficiency to getting the job they want. Then we'll briefly review fields that are potentially good matches for Commanders. However, with this ambitious type, it's shortsighted to limit the definition of a "good match," as they are likely to make anything they commit to fit.

The final sections will offer a detailed look at how Commanders interact with each of the four Role groups on the job. But this is not merely theoretical or academic. We hope these practical insights will help Commanders improve everyday work interactions, troubleshoot problems, correct blind spots, and build dynamic partnerships to make their workplace experiences more successful.

Excellent Leaders

To say that Commanders are influential leaders isn't just a feel-good sentiment. People with this personality type have excellent leadership skills and an inborn love of knowledge. They loathe incompetence, laziness, and inefficiency. This makes them strict and demanding – but also practical and objective managers. They believe that everyone should do their best to complete tasks to the highest possible standard and can't tolerate individuals who are incompetent or rely on their connections instead. Commanders have high standards, especially with their work, and they are likely to apply an extraordinary amount of effort to their jobs.

Commanders love turning their ideas into plans. This is one of their most important characteristics when it comes to working. They focus on the future and hold an air of self-confidence rarely seen among other personality types. These traits make Commanders excellent executives, entrepreneurs, and corporate strategists. But they are not relegated solely to upper-echelon, white-collar positions. They have enough drive and determination to push specific ideas forward even when many obstacles block their path. Their systemic focus and insight can play out at all employment levels and in all fields. For example, a Commander mechanic who has a comprehensive overview of a machine is likely to find solutions that might evade those who just learn how to fix things in a step-by-step manner.

Commanders can be excellent communicators (especially verbally) and enjoy structure and order, making them well-suited to leadership roles. Ideal Commander careers involve at least some management opportunities. It's unlikely that people with this personality type will remain happy as low-level employees for long. Some of their positive professional traits may surface only when they have enough power to use them.

Need for Challenge

Commanders rely on their intelligence, and they apply themselves more when a job tests their problem-solving skills. Problems are inherently novel – or someone already would have solved them. Commanders are likely to crave stimulating challenges and to shun routines and repetitive tasks. They enjoy digging deeply to understand a problem,

deconstructing the reasons it's problematic, and then building a system around their understanding to provide a solution.

If a system needs rethinking or has a chronic issue, Commanders are among the best to address it. They aren't afraid to work through a Gordian Knot of a problem – in fact, they're likely to rate their job satisfaction higher when there are enough issues to keep a job interesting. For people with this personality type, intellectual challenges are the lifeblood of their existence, and leading others to realize solutions brings them fulfillment.

Habitually Pondering

Commanders' fondness for planning, strategizing, and substantial pondering makes them ideal for jobs where they can encourage others to explore innovative ideas. Even in jobs that don't require creative thinking, Commanders often consider new perspectives anyway. The constant brainstorming feeds their preference to lead others to meet challenges.

Employers who request feedback get thoughtful summaries from Commanders, but only if they allow enough time for thorough analyses. Commanders, typically thoughtful and responsible in their approach, dislike having to assess something without fully considering everything first. However, in many cases, they may have been playing with ideas and considering possible improvements all along. It can be hard to catch people with this personality type by surprise; they are always looking for solutions and continually interacting with others to get a better handle on things.

Finding Opportunity

Knowing Commanders' general attitude toward work that's fulfilling and how they approach it, we can now turn to what they do to get there in the first place.

Martialing Self-Awareness

As with everything else, Commanders approach the career journey with strategy. They are likely to build careers rather than just find jobs. They may not see each detail involved in a desired position before applying,

but they likely have a good idea of how the position can feed into their broader career goals. Commanders do their homework and approach the job search knowledgeably. Consequently, their certainty gives them focus and confidence as they explore their choices.

Commanders know what they know – and they know what they don't know. This self-awareness provides them with an oxymoronic bold humility. They can be hard on themselves while simultaneously impressing others with their confident assertions. They're competent yet aware enough of their limitations, which makes them moldable and valuable assets in entry-level jobs, as well as other jobs with a learning curve.

People with this personality type are ambitious, and they enter the workforce with determined intentions. Once they adopt visions or plans, they martial all of their resources to fulfill them. Even from the beginning of their careers, they work on fortifying the foundations that support their goals. Such focus makes for serious employees. If Commanders can display their seriousness without overwhelming hiring teams with their intensity, they likely will win them over.

Making Contact

Although Commanders possess a gregarious, fun side, they also are serious. They're likely to meet their potential employment contacts at conventions or other meetups where focused interests are central. Trying to meet the right contacts at purely social cocktail parties isn't their style.

For the types of jobs that attract Commanders, the most effective emails and introductory phone calls center on their knowledge and interests rather than pleasantries and personality. Personal characteristics such as enthusiasm and reliability are always essential in an interview, but they may be secondary for specific jobs. They still need attention, but aptitude and understanding are critical for Commanders' presentations.

For an excellent first impression when applying for jobs that suit them, Commanders must be their best selves: knowledgeable, direct, friendly, and rational. Those characteristics, or even just a few of them, are likely all it takes to impress others at a first meeting. If they show they grasp an idea or a system, displaying an ability to navigate relevant subjects well, they're likely to impress interviewers. Commanders can

charm their interviewers, and charisma can work in small doses. But showing competence is their stronger suit for the jobs that will bring them satisfaction.

Outside Interests

Not all interviewers ask candidates about their more extensive interests, but organizations rarely seek one-dimensional employees with no life apart from work. Commanders might want to consider their hobbies and recreational activities and include that information on their résumés or mention it during an interview. There are plenty of opportunities to expand their areas of interest – they can hone in on a chosen art form, take a course to broaden their knowledge base, or finish writing a short story. Commanders needn't force it, but if becoming a more appealing candidate partially inspires them to take on an exciting hobby, all the better.

Such projects need not relate to the job, either. Anything that shows Commanders as creators can go on a résumé. This presents them as more attractive and versatile candidates and gives breathing room during interviews. Answering a question like, "Describe a situation where you used your problem-solving skills," is much, much easier with projects and anecdotes ready for discussion.

People with the Commander personality type may want to build ties with their communities and often provide leadership there. If they gain experience with volunteer, community, or student organizations, they can highlight that during their job searches. If Commanders take leadership roles in such undertakings, those related management skills can serve as a sturdy centerpiece in the job application process – especially if they are new to the job market.

Preparing for the Interview

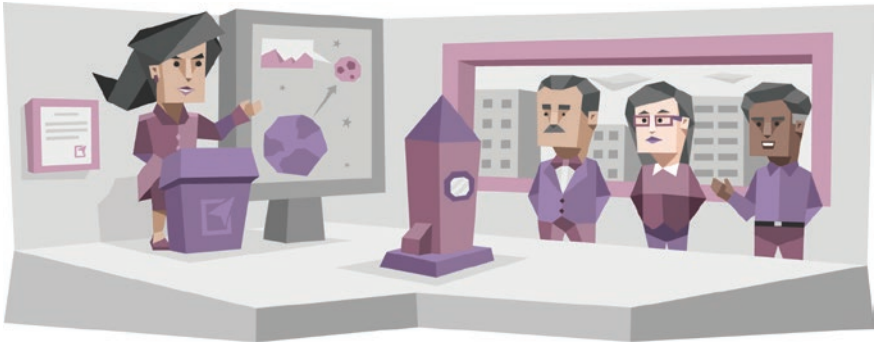
Commanders can spend time improving their presentation skills, whatever their natural ability. Although they are outgoing enough, they may not always read their audiences well or anticipate what's important to their listeners. Their style can be a little blunt; at times, diplomacy would serve them better. Commanders may want to role-play with an objective and honest friend to practice listening more carefully and to smooth out any rough edges.

Also, when they have an interview coming up, Commanders can radically overanalyze, trying to prepare for every imagined scenario. Overthinking is a trap most Intuitive types fall into easily. However, they can't possibly prepare for everything, but they can exhaust themselves ahead of the interview, undermining their chances.

Commanders' preference for original ideas can lead them to ignore more common interview questions. They may be caught off-guard by a typical question, such as "What's your biggest weakness," and fall back on a clichéd answer, such as "perfectionism." But when an interviewer is looking for self-awareness and introspection, responses that appear "canned" might kill the deal.

Therefore, it's crucial to anticipate template questions, especially in the preliminary stages of a job search, and to prepare to approach them with something near enthusiasm. Sometimes recruiters don't even know much about the roles and responsibilities. They may simply go through generic checklists. This can seem unchallenging and unproductive to Commanders, who may even have an impulse to take over during such a meeting. If they go in expecting well-worn questions, regardless of their personal feelings on the efficacy of such an approach, they are more likely to prevent confidence from clouding their judgment and disillusionment from overshadowing a good interview.

Jobs and General Skill Sets



Let's look at some specific jobs that fit Commanders well. This list is by no means comprehensive, as Commanders can succeed in any career they choose. Similarly, even "suitable" careers won't be ideal for all Commanders. Everyone must decide what career fits them best, meets their needs, and brings them fulfillment and personal satisfaction.

For Commanders who are already employed, this may serve as a confirmation or an explanation of why they're happy or unhappy in a role. We can't tell anyone exactly how to succeed or be happy, but we hope to offer some insight for Commanders making personal career decisions.

Innovation and Design

Engineering and design are broad categories of disciplines that use science, math, design techniques, and ingenuity to create machines, structures, or systems. People in these fields create new products, improve old ones, and find new applications for existing products. Such careers allow Commanders to tap into their creativity, a trait that many overlook but which plays a key role in Commanders' overall happiness.

Commanders have a knack for spotting trends and revealing fine points amid the noise of irrelevant details. They relish taking their observations and using them to improve existing organizational or technical methods or to build better alternatives. Their curiosity and need for efficiency make them excellent candidates for engineering and design roles. Although many engineers and designers labor alone over a drafting table, a computer, or a workbench, these fields also provide opportunities in leadership, teamwork, and project management.

Research and Science

Commanders need to discover how everything works. They love unearthing patterns through research and observations. Commanders enjoy exploring uncharted territory and finding novel approaches to old disciplines on their own initiative. Researchers and scientists with the Commander personality type admire others with similar drive and abilities. They collaborate most successfully when they feel they're dealing with equals – or those of superior ability and experience whom they can look up to. However, that doesn't mean that they don't also enjoy mentoring less experienced people, as long as the relationship is clearly defined. Fields that involve research and science can fulfill Commanders' need for forward-looking potential and can provide them opportunities to take the lead in projects.

Strategy

It's no accident that Commanders are part of a Role group called Analysts. Commanders see and manipulate systems, mentally dissecting them, identifying areas for improvement, then rebuilding them so they will be more useful. Calling this section "Strategy" is cheating a bit. Everything Commanders do is strategic, but not all strategic jobs fit neatly into categories. That said, some positions that fit under this heading where Commanders can excel and feel fulfilled include business administrator, management consultant, project manager, military officer, educational consultant, and investment analyst.

Challenging Career Qualities

In modern society, we spend a great deal of time at work, and we also tend to need our jobs to give us meaning. We must be careful not to get stuck in situations that don't suit us, as that can cause all manner of difficulties. Following are some characteristics of positions that may not be suitable for Commanders.

Some professions or jobs may be less suitable or comfortable for Commanders and may obstruct their success and happiness. Commanders shouldn't discount any career merely on face value because when these adaptable individuals put their minds to it, they can do anything. A job with challenging features should be seen less as a "stop" sign and more as a "caution" sign. Commanders must objectively evaluate specific jobs against their own needs, values, and limits. Such probing is essential to good decision-making. To aid Commanders in searching for job opportunities, let's look at some career characteristics and circumstances that present prominent challenges for people with this personality type.

Unhelpful Leadership

Commanders are natural leaders and often insist on things being "right." They show little tolerance for error or sloppiness. If those in charge are rigid with their concepts, or if the structure doesn't allow for employees to be heard or leaders to emerge from the ranks, Commanders may have problems. People with this personality type

accept rational arguments that are counter to their views, but if they determine that a position is based on "Because I'm the boss and I said so," they may begin to look down on their employers.

Commanders need an objective rationale for anything they think or do. They need room to create and inspire. If their management structure doesn't allow for this, they most likely will feel unfulfilled. In such situations, when they think their employers are in error, Commanders may not be able to overlook it – and they do like to take a stand.

Social Aspects of Work

Not being highly empathetic, Commanders probably won't respond well to any job that requires a significant amount of emotional intelligence. This is a somewhat unique trait for an Extraverted personality, but Commanders do tend to be somewhat reserved, especially in situations that don't revolve around their interests. People with this personality type tend to do fine with coworkers and clients when conversations are about their work, but they have little tolerance for much else while on the clock and just don't understand small talk.

Also, where there is social interaction, there eventually is emotion and drama. Such displays of feelings cause discomfort for Commanders, and they may even lose their bearings temporarily, not knowing how to respond. They may not enjoy business dinners or social events, which can be important in some industries.

Commanders most likely would struggle as, for example, marriage counselors. Feelings and emotions aren't their strong suit. Although they may enjoy interacting with others, it must be on a more intellectual level. A strong appeal to feelings, whether in life or an argument, turns off Commanders. On top of that, they often misread the emotional cues of others. Even though people with this personality type share the same emotions as anyone else, empathy included, they aren't comfortable dealing with that realm – particularly in the workplace. Jobs that demand a high level of compassion would likely be frustrating for them.

Lack of Intellectual Stimulation

Commanders need a great deal of intellectual stimulation and challenge to be satisfied. Unlike some other personality types, they never actually

satisfy their curiosity, and they're always looking for new puzzles and pursuing new angles on unsolved problems. For them, many career paths may feel unsuitable, as they may feel as though their employers underutilize their key skills.

Their minds are both their greatest gift and their most significant curse. When a work environment is a good fit, people with this personality type are quickly noticed and appreciated. If not, they may feel endlessly frustrated by inefficiencies and missed opportunities. Commanders tend to have many transferable skills and shouldn't hesitate to promote them – or even look for greener pastures when a job isn't a good match.

It's imperative that Commanders learn to find ways to use their strategic thinking skills whenever and wherever they can – even in positions that may be unstimulating. If they see that a role is unsuitable, they won't be able to shake the gnawing feeling that they're in the wrong place, no matter how well-paid or stable the position may be.

Alternative Options

Sometimes Commanders won't be able to advance at their current workplaces – either because their employers don't value their unique traits or because there just isn't room for growth. Aside from changing employers, there are alternative options – some of them unexpected – for Commanders who find themselves in this situation.

People don't need to be employed in the traditional sense to live comfortably. We live in an age of possibilities, and selling time to a corporation isn't the only way to generate income. Commanders are imaginative, bold individuals, and thanks to their ability to create new ideas and make complex connections, they can thrive in self-employment and as entrepreneurs.

Self-Employment

Many people find the notion of self-employment to be quite scary, but these days, even traditionally employed people rarely have job security or guarantees of advancement. Consequently, working for oneself can be a viable option, and it offers many benefits that align with Commander values, including flexibility, independence, and personal vision.

Furthermore, self-employment eliminates a significant hurdle Commanders encounter in traditional work environments: a lack of control over their duties. Although nobody has complete control over the tasks they must perform when making a living, self-employed people have more power than those following orders. Self-employed people still have administrative duties and certain obligations, but at least they have more of a say in how they handle all of it and whether they can delegate less-desirable tasks.

The self-employed route also appeals to Commanders' sense of self-determination. Once they put their mind to something – acquiring more clients, diversifying their work, increasing their expertise in their chosen field – Commanders are formidable forces. They may have the same amount of work or even more, but the reward is that they are their own bosses.

Entrepreneurship

Of course, there is no point in trying to start a business without a good idea. This is where Commanders' ability to come up with unusual connections and spot early trends enables them to shine. Anyone can think up a product, but it takes an imaginative mind to come up with an idea, product, or solution that could grow into an innovative business venture.

If Commanders decide to try their hand at entrepreneurship, they will need to rely on their creativity and strategic thinking skills to devise an interesting way to fulfill an existing need (or create one), all while not being afraid to experiment. Commanders can be excellent entrepreneurs, having both the imagination necessary to develop a good business model and the sheer drive and energy to keep going in difficult times.

Capitalizing on a Hobby

Commanders often pursue hobbies that could turn into sources of income in the future. The hobby can be anything, such as crafting innovative woodwork, building custom personal computers, making music, or consulting to improve communities. Some Commanders want to change the world, whereas others focus on local or personal matters. When people with this personality type enjoy a hobby, and if

they can retain the safety net of regular employment, they might create the next "big thing." If they are able to divert some financial resources to the hobby, so much the better.

This approach is common among Commanders, especially those in positions that are well-paid but not intellectually challenging. The right hobbies provide Commanders with opportunities to do things that truly excite and inspire them, without the constraints of employer-employee relationships. If they create value, they likely can find a way to become profitable in time and can tick another vital box on their happiness checklist – independence.

A side note for ambitious Commanders: People with this personality type are bound to overthink things and get bogged down trying to determine the path that's right for them. They should take time to think and reflect – but try not to obsess over details. Commanders usually are at their best when they're relaxed and confident in their skills.

When it comes to the professional world, it doesn't matter which path Commanders choose, as long as it works for them and is a source of inspiration. Although this is an idealistic perspective for many people, if any type can devise a system that makes one thing adapt to the purpose of another – transforming a hobby to an income generator, for example – it's Commanders.

Workplace Cooperation Between Types

Next, we will dig a little deeper to determine how Commanders can best cooperate with their coworkers from all four Role groups, including other Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers. Where do Commanders and colleagues of various personality types sync most easily? Where might they experience friction or incompatibility? From those insights comes specific advice for dealing with issues likely to arise from their differences, as well as how their likenesses can create synergy and successful collaboration.

Commander-Analyst Cooperation

The shared Intuition and Thinking traits make Commanders and Analysts "siblings" in a personality type "family." And there are family resemblances. Even with their similarities, they have plenty of nuances and differences, which can be positive or negative in a professional environment. The results depend as much upon Commanders and what approach they decide to take as they do on the behaviors and attitudes of their colleagues.

Balanced Commander-Analyst Cooperation

Lofty and Logical Language

Commanders and other Analysts often find themselves "speaking the same language." They both make rational arguments and engage in conceptual discussions. Although they draw on facts, their focus is on big-picture ideas. As puzzle-solvers, Commanders and other Analysts explore systems and concepts, engaging in "what if" discussions with each other. They share their ideas for improving any enterprise they come across. Small talk does not interest either party, and they may find each other relief from the tedium of water-cooler chat.

Commanders and other Analysts can be a perfect match when it comes to bouncing ideas off each other. Brainstorming sessions between these two are likely to extend into a series of discussions, as both take time to ponder the different facets of an idea. In the workplace, such interactions yield many benefits. For example, others might be able to feed a problem to this duo and pull out a solution a few minutes later. Analysts and other Commanders delight in being a sort of black-box solutions generator, fueled by their affinity for ideas mixed with potential solutions.

Covering Each Other's Bases

Commanders are adept at reverse-engineering any system; they can take a deconstructed methodology and apply or cut concepts until a system runs optimally. This type is not one for flourishes, instead preferring minimalist approaches focused on effectiveness, simplicity, and elegance. When it comes to problem-solving, Commanders are masters at fixing issues that have long-term implications in a broader structure, and they can be resolute, even stubborn, once a decision is made.

Other Analysts can back them up and "check their work." If they've earned a Commander's respect, they can serve as safeguards against errors and wrong ideas. Because they are Intuitive, Commanders also are typically open to the potential that can lie in alternate perspectives, and other Analysts usually can supply those in abundance. Rather than resist, Commanders and other Analysts are open to different angles.

Unbalanced Commander-Analyst Cooperation

Constant Competition

One pitfall Commander and Analyst coworkers may face is the potential for constant competitive tension. Because Analysts are somewhat rare, Commanders may not have had experience with other Analysts in the room. Such new encounters can be uncomfortable – especially if they come across other Analysts who share their specific specialties. In career settings with a high concentration of Analysts, the competition can be extreme. Although Commanders and other Analysts aren't prone to drama in an emotional sense, their one-upmanship can cause extensive damage if it spills too much into the workday.

If Commanders and other Analysts become competitive with each other, they can become entrenched in opposing ideas or unrelenting criticism of each other. Analysts are prone to freely show scorn for others' mistakes or displays of flawed logic. Terse remarks can ratchet up the heat as their egos become strongholds they must defend. Instead of a generous synergy of ideas that can take place between Commanders and other Analysts, they may develop a destructive rivalry designed to bring the other down in a display of intellectual superiority.

There also is a chance that the two will unite their competitive spirit against others. Commanders' desire to trample competitors can quickly turn toxic in the workplace. When another Analyst fans the flames, a situation can go from bad to terrible.

A Quagmire of Cleverness

Commanders and other Analysts who nurture their collaborative spirits can find themselves in a quagmire of genius. They could produce too many great ideas while brainstorming together. With each new plan requiring resources and entailing opportunity costs, Commanders and other Analysts may become trapped in their cleverness, unable to move any objective forward with the competence they so value. At some point, they may need to pull in fewer theoretical and more hands-on people to lend a practical perspective and to get things moving outside of the realm of the imagination.

Personality theories often refer to Intuitive types, like Commanders and other Analysts, as "open-minded." They are open-minded in that they can see many options, giving them the appearance of flexibility that may not always be present. However, Commanders and other Analysts can be as stubborn or rigid as anybody with ideas and obsessions – perhaps more.

Such stubbornness can be especially true when Commander and Analyst coworkers believe a pet argument is unassailable. But even when they are right about an idea, it doesn't mean it fits all situations. Remember the adage, "When one only has a hammer, everything becomes a nail." Rather than getting stuck pushing ideas that aren't relevant to a work situation or aren't accepted by the powers-that-be, Commander-Analyst teams may need to give up the designs they hold dear in the name of broader institutional goals.

Rebalancing Commander-Analyst Cooperation

Healthy Competition

Competition isn't necessarily bad, and its negative impact depends on the level of hostility. For Commanders and other Analysts, it's more about the tone of the rivalry. It's reasonable to believe that good ideas

and outcomes can arise when coworkers try to outdo each other – if they can keep it goal-oriented and thwart the need to make it a zero-sum game. If competition persists for a lengthy period, it can become a distraction. So, tone, attitude, and level of efficiency all determine the value of competition.

Self-awareness is one of the first steps for Commanders who wish to transform toxic work competition with other Analysts into a healthier version. Being more aware of their aggressive tendencies can help Commanders moderate their voices. They can choose to be contrary to confirm their sense of their own superiority, or they can choose to offer opposing viewpoints and new information to add significant new dimensions to work plans. Self-awareness provides choice and freedom and diminishes the power of compulsive competitiveness.

Setting up a system that fosters such insight can be a powerful tool for keeping toxic competition in check. The following method recognizes that the need to be right is not in and of itself a terrible thing – if used in moderation, it can motivate Commanders in healthy ways. However, the more exclusive the focus is on being right, the less likely it is to contribute in a wholesome manner. The following exercise is designed to increase mindful awareness of attitudes:

- Find an index card that's small enough to fit in a pocket or planner. It's helpful to have something physical and straightforward to anchor the process and to keep you from overthinking it.
- Draw a line across the index card. On one end of the line, write, "Winning." On the other, write, "Contributing."
- Set a random alarm app on a cell phone or set some other type of randomized reminder. Each time it goes off, take out the index card and ask, "Where do my thoughts and focus fall on this continuum at this moment?" (Obviously, this is a forced dichotomy. The goal is not to label every part of every day perfectly, but rather to ask yourself a question to raise your awareness. Avoid concretizing it into a system that demands an "efficient" answer. The goal of this mindfulness exercise is to stop, to think, and to become more aware. Nothing more.)
- Do this for a week to build a habit.

Keep the card as needed in the future. If an interaction feels tense and adversarial, take out the card and think about the motivation fueling the sense of competition.

If the personal need to triumph hinders measurable goals or decelerates progress, it is objectively damaging. A focus that falls somewhere in the middle of the line can be acceptable, and a wish to win may also be motivational. Remember, reasonable competition can be useful. However, if Commanders discover that "winning" motivates them more often than not, they may want to adjust their approach to ensure their value in the workplace. It starts with awareness.

Opening the Echo Chamber

At work, Commanders and other Analysts who share rational sensibilities can offer each other intellectual stimulation without having to wander too far from their comfort zones. With each reinforcing the other, they can create a sense of confidence or legitimacy around their ideas that isn't always deserved. That an opinion is well-reasoned doesn't necessarily make it useful, and Commander and Analyst coworkers can become stuck supporting notions that are worthless outside their bubbles.

People often ignore theories that don't have clear and measurable results. This is especially true in for-profit settings. Although lofty thoughts can be fun for Commanders and other Analysts to toss back and forth, they can be detrimental if they become a focus or are mistaken for useful. In certain situations, Commander and Analyst coworkers may need to recognize when they're stuck in a loop of their own mental indulgences, then discover ways to break the cycle.

Some fundamental questions they might ask themselves:

- What concrete and measurable results are likely to result from this line of thinking?
- How does this idea align with our organization's established vision or mission statement? If it doesn't, is the group seeking to modify its overarching goals?

- How much resistance is the idea likely to receive? Rank it from 1 (received with joy and fanfare) to 10 (likely a deal-breaker when it comes to keeping this job). If the number is low, the idea may be worth pursuing. If the number is moderate, it may just be a matter of selling the idea correctly or tweaking it slightly to improve the rating. If the number is high, perhaps the idea should be shelved.
- Has the idea been reviewed by management or peers for its relevance? Do others appear to be on board with the concept? Who has the authority to decide such things?

If reflections from the above questions reveal that the idea should not move forward, use the following suggestions to let go.

- Recognize that shelving an idea doesn't say anything about the quality of the idea, nor does it measure your worth. Plans are adopted when they are in the right place at the right time.
- Give opposing or alternate views a fair hearing.

Similarly, adopt a "Beginner's Mind." Beginner's Mind is a Zen principle of approaching everything with a fresh set of eyes. It forces its practitioners to drop preconceptions – an obvious step for letting go when stuck in an unproductive cycle. Ask yourself, "If I was approaching this situation for the first time, what might I notice about it?" But that doesn't mean you need to abandon your experiences. Beginner's Mind involves using your experiences in a new way based on new perceptions or revised circumstances.

Jeffrey McDaniel wrote, "I realize there's something incredibly honest about trees in winter, how they're experts at letting things go." Commanders are not always so good at releasing their pet notions. However, letting go is a useful skill they can develop to gain much benefit. Letting go can save time spent on futile endeavors, conserving personal energy and mental capacity. It also may help Commanders when they find themselves trapped with Analyst coworkers in an echo chamber of ideas.

Commander-Diplomat Cooperation

Commander and Diplomat coworkers share the Intuitive Trait, which provides them a place to connect regardless of any differences they may have. A kinship emerges from their collective ability to see beyond the obvious. Their differences are as likely to offer wholesome balance as they are to create conflict – it depends on their willingness to work together and to appreciate one another's gifts and preferences.

Balanced Commander-Diplomat Cooperation

Some Common Methods

Commanders and Diplomats both prefer discussing the "big picture" over individual details. Small talk may bore even the most social among them. Both absorb new knowledge almost subconsciously and then incorporate it into a larger constellation of Intuitive understanding. Both exercise an often intense and unexpected imaginative and creative ability to connect the dots.

These similarities, along with their shared love of unconventional thinking, give Commanders and Diplomats plenty of common ground and opportunities to combine their talents. Both groups are statistically rare, and they are likely to recognize that they are not like most of their coworkers – depending on the job. Some positions attract more Intuitive people than others. However, in the average random workplace, Diplomats and Commanders may find they enjoy the conversations they have with each other and discover a stimulating level of compatibility. Although they may focus on different things while brainstorming, they both are typically adept at producing copious novel ideas when called on to do so. They are likely to quickly identify each other as "idea people," like themselves.

Complementary Perspectives

Commanders are comfortable with systems and puzzles, and they value innovation over all else. They excel at working things out, at least to the extent that they offer theories toward that end. Diplomats add to Commanders' offerings by bringing humanity to their ideas, providing "soul" to any system that Commanders devise or innovate. It would be a cartoonish portrayal to say that Commanders lack humanity and Diplomats are bereft of analytical skills. But when Commanders enthusiastically push an idea forward, Diplomats may be there to remind them that people need adjustment periods before they can accept innovation. Commanders, on the other hand, can help Diplomats move more efficiently through the drama that often occurs on the job.

In a workplace, this might play out as a wholesome push-and-pull between the logical and the compassionate. A great product without sensitive customer service is likely to gain a bad reputation. Then again, what is the point of outstanding customer service if the product or service isn't viable?

Unbalanced Commander-Diplomat Cooperation

When Efficiency Hinders Support

As much as their Intuition binds them, Commanders and Diplomats still have pronounced differences. Each brings a different emphasis, and if they add inflexibility and intolerance, these coworkers can have problems. Commanders' rapid-fire ideas may not always consider how others might react as they plow ahead trying to implement their concepts. However, concerns over how an aggressive push might affect others is likely a prominent blip on Diplomats' radars, which can cause them to automatically feel at odds with their Commander colleagues. Without looking for some middle ground that honors efficiency and innovation yet also considers the feelings, sensibilities, and esteem of those involved, the two may retreat to their own corners and stubbornly insist that the other is wrong.

For example, Commanders may see projects as hindered by those who are slower to accept change, believing that the best approach is to force them to move forward or remove them from the loop entirely.

Passionate focus on their current ideas may pull Commanders away from a more sensitive and patient plan that allows time for personnel to adjust on a psychological level. On the other hand, Diplomats may spend too much time worrying about the feelings and concerns of others, bogging down progress. Cue a lot of impatience on both sides.

Blunt and Gentle Expressions

Commanders and Diplomats may find that their outward expressions are also points of contention. When dealing with people who don't see things their way, Commanders can be brusque and impatient, causing Diplomats frustration and disappointment. Diplomats tend to avoid conflict, and they may disengage if Commanders come across as too harsh or condescending. Diplomats need not even be the target for this problem to arise; in some instances, Diplomats may take a stand if they believe Commanders' attitudes are hurtful to others' feelings or welfare.

To be clear, Commanders aren't uncaring people, and their bluntness is often delivered in a spirit of support. But they rarely see the point of sugar-coating their solutions or objections just to spare others' feelings. Their version of truth or reality comes before such things. This can easily create tension between them and people wearing the label of "Diplomat." Commanders' hearts may be in the right place, but they don't always come across that way. As rationally intelligent as Commanders strive to be, and as social as they are, they're notorious for lacking emotional intelligence. Whereas Commanders have no problem with (or even enjoy) criticism and debate, Diplomats are acutely sensitive to contentious words and may shut down.

Rebalancing Commander-Diplomat Cooperation

Starting with Understanding

Commanders who hope to sync better with Diplomats at work may want to discover what values are essential to Diplomats. Learning what motivates them can bridge the gap of understanding. That doesn't mean they must surrender their styles or positions – it simply involves the intention to learn about their Diplomat coworkers. The approach draws on that which Commanders value: acquiring information to draw conclusions. To do this, however, Commanders may need to

deliberately open themselves to such information rather than assume that they already have a read on their compassionate colleagues. It's easy to stereotype those who are different – perhaps in this case as "bleeding hearts" – and to go no further in understanding them.

Commanders and Diplomats may reconnect if they remember that they both want to make a difference. Their methods and desired results may be dissimilar, but these innovative people share a desire to improve anything they're involved with – even if in different ways. Once they understand their shared wish for improvement, they can explore the details by employing the journalistic questions: "who," "what," "when," "where," "why," and "how." The answers can help these coworkers reach a deeper level of appreciation for each other's opinions and ideas. It's essential to understand that acceptance and support don't always require agreement or approval. It's okay to disagree, and with their diverse styles, Commanders and Diplomats may work together best if they agree to disagree on some issues. But that shouldn't excuse either from making attempts to understand the other with the goal of having a better working relationship.

Those who are interested in better understanding can try a five-minute time-out from judgment. Commanders can do the following simple exercise on their own, without necessarily discussing it with their Diplomat coworkers, or they can set it up with their Diplomat colleagues if the situation is comfortable enough:

- Pick a mutual work topic to ask questions about.
- Establish a short period of time during which judgment will be suspended (e.g., five minutes).
- Start a discussion as if you are a non-interfering anthropologist or sociologist who is trying to collect information without influencing the direction of the native population. Or perhaps take on the persona of an objective journalist. Remember that the goal of the exercise is simple, non-judgmental data collection.

Borrow heavily from the journalistic questions and fire away. Statements are not allowed, nor are questions that make your Diplomat coworker defend their position. For example, "Do you really think that is the right approach?" is a forbidden question.

After the time is up, take a moment to write an objective, nonjudgmental paragraph describing the Diplomat's position. If the Diplomat is in on the exercise, perhaps ask them to review the description for accuracy.

Those who execute this five-minute time-out from judgment will experience two things. First, Commanders will gain a focused, purer understanding of their Diplomat coworkers' opinions or ideas, free from interpretation and their own filters. From there, any arguments and disagreements will be based on complete understanding. Second, the Diplomats will feel they have been heard and that their ideas are valued – thus strengthening the working relationship.

Learning the Language of Diplomacy

There is nothing Commanders can do to change the nature of their more sensitive coworkers. They even may do themselves and their organization a service by accepting that Diplomats' sensitivity has value, even in the most impersonal workplaces. Learning to soften their sometimes-blunt speech can go a long way toward supporting coworkers who bring a more human element to the table. It's not necessarily that Commanders aren't aware of social graces. They are and can use them when they choose to. It's just that, at times, they may forget that others aren't as laser-focused on what is effective to the point that they forget the feelings and egos of others.

Commanders who learn to put a social buffer around their starker offerings take giant steps toward simpatico work relationships. Just as a car may need time to warm up on a cold morning, Commanders can understand the importance of investing in a friendly connection before getting down to brass tacks. When Commanders show more social grace and positivity to Diplomat colleagues, rather than taking a challenging or contentious stance, much more productive communication and cooperation are likely to blossom. Although none of the following gestures may be new to the average Commander, still, at times, they may need a gentle reminder of effective social niceties.

- Greet coworkers with a smile.
- Ask how their day is going.
- Give them a few moments to talk about themselves before replying.

- Pick some aspect of their response and reply complimentarily. If they talk about what they've been doing, something like, "Wow, that's cool!" is about right. If their response is a complaint, reply with something like, "Ugh, that really sucks!" or "I know that must be rough for you."
- Instead of giving "me" or "I" statements, even if related, stay focused on what *they're* saying.
- After sharing some interest in their day, make a "gotta get back to it" excuse and move on with work.

When there's a work matter to bring up, use a short version of this, rather than immediately launching into business.

It's essential for Commanders not to view themselves as deficient just because they don't place as much emphasis on socialization in the workplace – their way has its merits. However, practicing skills that let them relate better to Diplomats will create the efficient communication this type craves. A pinch of sugar can keep ideas and facts flowing freely, getting Commanders and Diplomats back to their shared creative ground.

Commander-Sentinel Cooperation

Commanders and Sentinels have fundamental differences in their intent and methods. Commanders love to experiment with the potential of a system, whereas Sentinels attend to straightforward business in the here and now, performing practical tasks and building order that supports established goals. When a job suits them, Commanders and

Sentinels may gravitate toward different, but often complementary, roles. Both seek effectiveness and results, and when they marry their approaches cheerfully and respectfully, they can move mountains.

Balanced Commander-Sentinel Cooperation

Implementing Solutions Together

In some ways, this is a perfect workplace match, as Commanders often need others to help them carry out their visions, and Sentinels tend to be efficient actors. Commanders are masters of thought and theory, but partnering with Sentinels can help them refine their ideas into practical plans that yield results. When Commanders reveal a novel approach, Sentinels cautiously start examining the applications – and costs – in the real world, nicely balancing Commanders' often passionate embrace of the new. Commanders are among the more practical of the Analysts, and Sentinels can help anchor them even more.

Translating broader ideas into specific realities is reversible, in that Commanders' creative approach can hold solutions to conventional problems as well. When Sentinels run up against a roadblock, Commanders may offer original thinking to get things back on track. Their imaginations can be the tonic that cures outdated or ineffective practices – something both Commanders and Sentinels rail against. When both accept how each other's unique approaches can contribute to productivity and draw on their respective strengths, they can become invaluable partners.

Planning

Another area of balance these two offer each other on the job is future thinking and planning. Commanders virtually live in a realm of possibility, always thinking about what the future can be crafted into. Sentinels try to control the present, creating stability in the face of the unknown. They plan for the future but mostly in the context of how they can act in the present to bring it about. When Commanders share their own forward-looking views, Sentinels see more possibilities than they might on their own. Together, they can envision the future and plan accordingly.

Commanders and Sentinels both are more comfortable with the predictable and orderly (even if they define the terms a bit differently), so they are likely to be respectful of each other's approaches, knowing that they are fundamentally grounded in responsible reality. They also are likely to mutually judge their lines of attack as both credible and valuable.

Unbalanced Commander-Sentinel Cooperation

Degrees of Change

There's an old saying: "Nobody likes change except a wet baby." But this isn't entirely true. Intuitive types like Commanders love change (though some prefer more thorough preparation than others). They seek improvement as a matter of course because it represents growth and possibilities to them. Yet, Sentinels adhere to proven standards and traditions, and they like to work within existing norms. Commanders have little regard for the status quo, especially if it gets in the way of improving a system. Sentinels may insist on doing something the "right way," according to how it's always been done; meanwhile, Commanders may insist on doing it a new "right" way, regardless of how it's always been done.

Commanders like radical changes – if they bring them up or a respected person carefully lays out the details, implementation, and consequences. Sentinels, however, prefer incremental change that improves on existing systems in clear ways. The conflict between tradition and change is as old as humanity itself, and it can indeed create problems in the workplace. Between Commanders and Sentinels, this tension can play out in the form of passive-aggressively resisting or discounting each other's contributions.

Rising Resentment

When Sentinels push for short-term specifics or plans that seem too small, Commanders might judge them as unimaginative. In turn, Commanders may find themselves labeled as constant agitators who won't leave "good enough" alone.

In relationships plagued by too narrow of an understanding, Commanders may lose respect for Sentinels' opinions, not consulting

them regarding decisions. As a result, they lose the benefit of Sentinels' diligent, detail-oriented approach. Although Commanders may think they're better off without Sentinels' input, their unwillingness to collaborate with these colleagues can cause frustration and headaches when it's time to implement or troubleshoot projects – two areas where Sentinels excel.

To communicate more effectively, Commanders may need to pull their punches a bit. They would do well to understand that Sentinels may react badly to harsh comments and off-the-cuff negative feedback. Because Sentinels are so invested in doing the work they do, maintaining balance, and ensuring things run well, they sometimes take criticism toward an organization or others very personally.

Rebalancing Commander-Sentinel Cooperation

Understanding How to Change

Nothing makes Sentinels feel better than crossing tasks off their lists, and Commanders, with their continuous stream of ideas, can provide an enormous number of tasks for their Sentinel colleagues to complete. This process is only useful, however, if Commanders understand the concept of sensitive, grounded change.

Change, especially when based only on theories and ideas, can make Sentinels uncomfortable. Commanders can allay their Sentinel coworkers' concerns and hesitation if they link their ideas and theories to practical, specific tasks. When suggesting changes to a current system, Commanders who bring forward ideas based on cutting-edge theories are likely to be met with skepticism from Sentinel coworkers. To counteract this, Commanders can try the following:

- Highlight the objective (for example, increase the number of customers using a particular cutting-edge Internet presence to build a community).
- Create a roadmap that shows how the idea will be incorporated into the current structure, as well as what it will look like in one month, three months, six months, and so on.

- Provide a date for when the new idea will be fully integrated into the system.
- Highlight practical tasks and smaller steps, as well as deadlines, increasing the odds of expected results.
- Allow plenty of time for change to take place so Sentinels can feel more comfortable with the transition and be more knowledgeable of any technical aspects of the change process.

Moving beyond the status quo may seem a noble pursuit to innovative Commanders, but Sentinels who prefer to uphold tradition may feel that their views have been overlooked and unappreciated. Commanders should remember that overeager criticism or impatience elicits resistance from even the most supportive Sentinels.

The remedy for this potential pitfall is to focus on patience, gratitude, and sincere respect for the many strengths that Sentinels bring to the workplace. Specifically, Sentinels' attention to detail is an incredible benefit to Commanders. It has been said that Commanders (and other Analysts) create the trains, but Sentinels keep them running on time. Awareness of the symbiotic nature of their workplace relationship fosters mutual respect and appreciation.

Practicing Patience and Awareness

Disagreement can overwhelm Commander-Sentinel relationships in the workplace, but this pair has immense potential for productive, positive interaction. Awareness is essential – especially when it comes to competitive urges, which can trigger stonewalling or unduly harsh criticism.

This doesn't mean that Commanders and Sentinels always agree with each other or come to the same conclusions. Both should practice patience and allow each other to prove – or fail to prove – their points of view in their own time and in their own way. Disagreements are bound to take place as Commanders push their visions and Sentinels resist in favor of the tried and true. Nothing sidelines a project faster than a drawn-out discussion about innovative concepts versus concrete traditions between Commanders and Sentinels. When faced with a situation like this, Commanders can try the following:

- Make the decision to put a "pin" in the conversation or save it for later.
- Tell your colleague that the issue can be discussed further when the schedule is less pressing: after work hours, for instance, or on another workday.
- Regularly ask your Sentinel colleague for advice on how to translate ideas into concrete terms, as this is their strong suit. Solicit feedback regarding which aspects of a plan should be more specific or actionable.
- If suggesting a change, support your argument by outlining tangible rather than intangible benefits.

By bridging the gap between their grandiose ideas and specific goals, Commanders can win over Sentinels and pave the way for success. To communicate effectively with Sentinels, Commanders can ground their use of abstract terms like "vision" and "innovate" with concrete details. This might entail outlining specific benchmarks they'd like to hit, as opposed to reciting a mission or vision; or perhaps they can discuss the tangible upsides of a novel approach rather than the intangible benefits.

Commander-Explorer Cooperation

Though there may seem to be little common ground between Commanders and Explorers, one only need dig deeper. They share a fascination with discovery that drives personal achievement. They both value independence and discovery over rules and tradition. They

especially enjoy turning a fixed idea on its head, creating a whole new perspective. Their shared perspectives enable Commanders and Explorers to work together as innovators.

Balanced Commander-Explorer Cooperation

Combining Vision with Action

Both Commanders and Explorers enjoy searching for answers. Although Commanders enjoy theorizing about ideas and systems, Explorers would rather solve problems in a hands-on fashion. Commanders prefer to think through potential outcomes before acting, whereas Explorers can't wait to start. At their best, the two can embark on a two-step process. Commanders can create ideas, then ask Explorers to join them in a partnership to make the ideas reality. Because people with the Commander personality type can struggle with implementation due to fixation on details, Explorer colleagues who are more action-oriented can help move projects along.

Consider the story of *Apollo 13*, a NASA space mission in 1970. After a mechanical mishap, the nation wasn't sure whether the three U.S. astronauts on board the spacecraft could make it back to Earth alive. The ground control team in Houston can be thought of as Commanders (or any Analyst type). The Commander ground control team members calculated all the numbers and worked out a trajectory that could get the astronauts home.

The astronauts on board the spacecraft served as Explorers, doing the hands-on work and carrying out the details the Commanders had provided, and they eventually got the capsule home. Communication between the ground control team and the astronauts was vital to the success of the *Apollo 13* rescue. The analogy shows how Explorers' and Commanders' contrasting roles and styles can work together to fulfill the same goal.

Appreciating Levity

Between Commanders and Explorers, the biggest issue may be the former's issue with the latter's seeming disregard of consequences. To Commanders, Explorers can appear as though they're only around

to have fun, with very little care for the end game. However, when Commanders decide to appreciate Explorers' strengths, particularly in the workplace, wonderful things can happen.

As colleagues, Commanders can help keep things on track, lending focus to their Explorer coworkers, and Explorers can lighten the mood of sometimes excessively serious Commanders. When working, Commanders can model a more focused and energetic attitude, while also keeping in mind that Explorers can help them to relax a bit – even the most serious Commanders need a break.

Unbalanced Commander-Explorer Cooperation

Strategic Meets Impulsive

Although Commanders and Explorers can work together well, the combination presents some potential problems. Explorers' focus on the present may annoy Commanders, who may see constant attention to the immediate as uninteresting and mundane. With Commanders, there always are bigger fish to fry, and they may lose patience if they feel bogged down in current, hands-on details. Commanders often feel condescending toward people they don't think mix well into their world of strategic design and complex future notions, and they may see those who deal mostly in hands-on solutions as somehow inferior to visionaries such as themselves. When they voice their disdain as direct criticism, communication with their Explorer coworkers can quickly shut down.

If Commanders' way of thinking is too theoretical for too long, it can lead Explorers to see them as unrealistic, unintelligible, and disengaged from "real life" in any practical way. Explorers aren't known for impulse control, and when their frustration hits a high mark, they may suddenly lose patience, either dismissing Commanders and withdrawing their support or just criticizing them outright. When the two become unhappy with each other, Commanders may resort to displays of smug arrogance. Meanwhile, Explorers typically move forward however they see fit, merely ignoring Commanders if they need to. Dysfunction ensues.

Misaligned Priorities

In stark contrast to Commanders, Explorers often downplay consequences. Given a choice between a bird in the hand or two in the bush, Commanders will choose the two in the bush – though, with the benefit of retrospect, they may regret passing up one in hand. Explorers, on the other hand, tend to shy away from long-term planning and prioritize immediate gains.

In the workplace, this can manifest as priority misalignment. Commanders tend to focus on building lasting relationships with clients and upholding their word, whereas Explorers often favor risky ventures with big payoffs. If communication breaks down, Commanders may judge their Explorer colleagues as shortsighted or trigger-happy. Meanwhile, Explorers may dismiss Commanders as impractical or uptight. If they don't collaborate, Commanders can miss out on exciting opportunities, and Explorers may lose sight of the big picture.

Rebalancing Commander-Explorer Cooperation

Respecting Distinct Types of Genius

Despite their differences, Commanders and Explorers can achieve success in the workplace. Balancing their very different styles begins with mutually understanding each other's strengths and weaknesses, as well as their own.

Often, Explorers can bring ideas to life in ways Commanders would never have thought possible. Genius comes in many forms, and Explorers' genius relies on adaptation and execution. Commanders' focus on facts may seem tedious to Explorers – not because Explorers want to blatantly reject Commanders' style, but because it doesn't occur to them to behave in such an exact manner or to analyze a situation into the ground.

Commanders are notorious for explaining their ideas in abstract, theoretical ways, but Explorers are likely to become bored with long-winded, conceptual matters. Instead of theoretical diatribes, Commanders can ground and "concretize" their sometimes-interminable approaches using methods like the following:

- Focus on sharing a quick overview of your idea, complete with the intro and the conclusion – but skipping most of the body.
- Be aware that not everybody connects to thorough discussions. Look for any chance to stop explaining.
- Take a step back from your Explorer colleague and respect the need for space. They are generally independent and prefer to find their way. Honor that to the degree you can.
- Check in with your Explorer coworker from time to time and *briefly* make sure you're both on the same page.

Although Commanders often are brilliant problem-solvers, they may become paralyzed if they get mired in detail. Because many Explorers thrive under pressure, Commanders benefit from having such teammates, to whom they can turn when circumstances overwhelm their abilities. Both Commanders and Explorers are focused on efficiency, with the former addressing the "why" and the latter addressing the "how." Each can benefit from the other's strengths when addressing a problematic situation, becoming helpful allies once they understand the useful qualities each brings to the table.

Understanding Priorities

In difficult working relationships with Explorers, Commanders may choose to block out Explorers' style instead of accepting the differences in their approaches with an open mind. But stonewalling comes at a cost because it often curtails any chance of collaboration. Trying to understand and work with Explorers' priorities can increase the chances of overall success.

To revive communication, Commanders might consider how much more effective it is to collaborate with, rather than work around, another individual. Once they acknowledge and accept that, it becomes easier for them to relax as Explorers do things in their fashion. With that comes comfort and perhaps even admiration, which may drive a greater collaborative spirit.

- Focus on listening, learning, and asking questions rather than debating or being right.

- Express curiosity about what your Explorer colleagues are doing, asking open-ended questions. However, be careful to make it part of friendly conversation rather than interrogation. Nobody likes to be grilled, and Explorers are likely to feel put off if questions seem like scrutiny rather than genuine interest.
- Take some time to get know coworkers as something more than beings who work at the same place. You may be tempted to reduce Explorers to their work roles and to judge them entirely by how they fit into your roles, plans, or ideas. A more well-rounded perspective can help you understand how coworkers think and what's important to them beyond your own narrow context. Have lunch or coffee with coworkers on occasion; it's a healthy way to build work relationships.
- Don't be afraid to try it their way occasionally. Growth comes from expanding beyond your own comfort zone, and Explorers certainly can help. Instead of reflexively criticizing, either silently or out loud, be curious and see where Explorers' more kinetic style leads once in a while. Doing so may offer you an interesting and new perspective.

Resourceful and tenacious, Explorers care about getting things done and moving projects forward. If they try to build honest and respectful relationships, Commanders may come to admire the proactive, fearless spirit that Explorer colleagues bring to the workplace.

Conclusion

Designing the Future

Commanders bring innovation, steadfast energy, and necessary efficiency to their positions, qualities that can easily help strengthen an organization. People with this personality type are likely to be on the cutting edge of experimentation, imagining ways to make the workplace the most effective version of itself. The key for Commanders is allowing themselves to appear warmer at work, as well as learning how to customize their approach to different individuals.

Fortunately, Commanders possess the ability to improve upon all things, especially themselves. They are the ones to turn to when ideas need to be catapulted or reinforced. They create success for themselves

through dedication and efficiency-based idealism, and they have the capacity to carry their ideals throughout their entire career.

Most of all, Commanders refuse to let go of the vision they have for themselves, seeking opportunities to work where they feel intellectually stimulated and effective. With work and determination, they can find a place to plant the seed of their professional vision, then feed it and make it grow. In the end, Commanders have all the tools they need for success.

Final Words

Achieving Inner Satisfaction

Some people might wonder what good success is unless it also brings with it a sense of happiness and fulfillment. Commanders think in rationalistic terms and may not often stop to contemplate the intangible effects of their academic and professional achievements. Yet each of their successes serves to boost their sense of pride and security – as can the failures and stumbles that served as learning opportunities on the road to success. While they may set their sights on the future, Commanders benefit from honoring the joys, the knowledge, and even the scars that resulted from where they've been.

Progress can be a linear thing, and for Commanders, it's likely a lifelong thing. These dynamic personality types rarely rest on their laurels for long – they're always looking for the next idea to act on or challenge to overcome. That mindset can serve them extremely well if it's not taken so far that it prevents them from continually appreciating how far they've come and what they've achieved. Whether academic or professional, every success is meant to be enjoyed on its own merits, not merely as a stepping stone to further success or a box to be ticked off.

Commanders who take the time to revel in every increment of their progress may find themselves enjoying the road to success just as much as any of the grand destinations that they eventually reach. That's a wonderful state for a personality type often obsessed with achievement milestones, as it can ensure their enthusiasm and satisfaction throughout the process of achieving goals, as well as in the moments that they achieve them.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want to kick-start your career or get better at navigating it? Explore our Career Specialized Tests.
- Looking to set a foundation for learning and developing as a person? Check out the *Commander Guide to Personal Growth*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Commander Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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